

The British Government in India had always advocated the positive economic impact of the railways in the country, promoting its role in India's march towards progress. Indian leaders, including Dadabhai Naoroji, however, took a more considered view. They recognized that the system served British interests first. Yet, it had become intrinsic to the country's social fabric. Historian Bipan Chandra wrote that these leaders were "champions of modern industry" and so were not against the railways. They merely realized that in order for the railways to become a truly "Indian" system, it had to play a bigger role in people's lives. It could no longer be a mere mode of transport, but a system that fostered Indian interests and industry and was also conscious of the needs of Indian travellers.

There was also an awareness, which came about as early as the 1870s, of the role the railways played in the depletion of the country's resources and diminished benefits. It was no wonder then that it became a key part of the nationalists' agenda.

For the people

The condition of the third-class traveller was uppermost on every Indian leader's mind. Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi's essay "Third-Class Travelling" condemned the appalling accommodation they were given and how they were treated. Just as important, and keenly debated at the Imperial Legislative Council of India in March 1911, was the need to employ more Indians in the upper ranks of the railways. Political leader GK Gokhale discussed this at great length in his landmark speech at the Council. By the 1920s, more and more communities joined this call for Indian diversity. With each passing year, leaders also got involved in the workings of the railways. They concerned themselves with a variety of matters, from the dismissal of a machineman at an Eastern Bengal Railway workshop to whether the Government was taking the right steps to address the demands of railway employees. In 1925, Jawaharlal Nehru, as chairman of the Allahabad Municipal Board, imposed taxes on the railways to support the debt-ridden civic body. This audacious step proved beneficial as the money was also used to provide facilities, such as water to passengers.